When I commanded 9 Maratha LI we had two superseded officers, including my second-in-command. Despite this we did very well as we worked as a team and everyone put in his best. As a brigade commander in Kashmir, I was given the responsibility of guarding the LoC and preventing infiltration, without having the powers to write the confidential reports of officers of the units placed under my operational control. And yet, our operational performance was exceptionally good, and we were counted amongst the top achievers in the entire Northern Command. We learnt the cliché – pay, play and pray with the men – early on in regimental soldiering. Providing an environment in the unit or formation in which esprit de corps is omnipresent is the acme of true military leadership.

Only if the soldiers feel that you genuinely care for them, can one aspire to be remembered as a good military leader. Bonding with my subordinates and the soldiers has been one of my strengths. Wherever possible, I reached out to them and shook hands and spoke with as many of them as possible. During early August 2007, one of our patrols discovered by chance the debris of an old aircrash in the Lahaul region of the Himalayas. An AN 12 had crashed on the way to Leh in 1968, and despite our best efforts, the site of the wreckage had not been located till then. We were able to retrieve and hand over the bodies of four soldiers to their families with due military honours.

Another leadership trait that I have found very effective is perseverance and doggedness in pursuit of an objective. History has made us aware of the razor-thin difference between victory and defeat in many a battle. The side that refused to throw in the towel or persevered longer carried the day. Once a decision has been taken it must be relentlessly pursued to its logical culmination.

Regardless of how grandiose our war plans are, we cannot succeed without the ‘fighting spirit’ of our soldiers. To emerge victorious in any war we need a force that is well-attuned to operational tasks and is adequately rested. We must make sure the army is mentally and physically charged and is raring to go, if we wish to win the race from the start to finish. As commented earlier, some self-centred commanders want to make a name for themselves